

Sydney Opera House

In 1956, the government of New South Wales announced an international competition to design a new opera house for Sydney. The site was to be a promontory with views to the sea and the Harbour Bridge. The winning design, from a little-known Danish architect, Jørn Utzon (1918–2008), featured overlapping white roofs that covered the building's two main halls, seeming to emerge from the water and resembling the sails of giant yachts; Utzon claimed he was inspired by the act of peeling an orange. But when the design led to structural problems, Utzon replaced his elliptical shells with a new concept based on sections of a sphere. The Opera House, though controversial among the public, became an icon of Sydney and is today one of the world's most recognizable buildings. Its glass walls are secured by vertical steel mullions, and chevron-patterned ceramic tiles cover the sculptural roofs. Inside, high vaulted ceilings are covered in curving plywood panels, and canopies of glass held by steel ribs cover the foyers and bars – inspired, according to Utzon, by birds' wings.

